



Health Insurance and Municipal Registration Guide

For First-Year International Students in the Netherlands

Fontys University of Applied Sciences

2025 Edition

Welcome to the Netherlands

As a new international student in the Netherlands, two of the most important tasks you'll face early on are obtaining proper health insurance and registering with the local municipality. These steps are essential for complying with Dutch law and getting everything you need (like a BSN number) to live and study in the Netherlands.

This guide will walk you through each process with clear steps, so that by the end you'll be fully prepared to start your student journey at Fontys.

Health Insurance for International Students

Important: In the Netherlands, it is mandatory by law for everyone living here (including international students) to have health insurance. However, the type of insurance you need depends on your situation.



1 Make sure you're insured – it's required

All students, whether EU or non-EU, must have valid health insurance while living in the Netherlands. It's your responsibility to arrange proper coverage either before or immediately upon arriving. Universities will check this because it's a governmental obligation.

2 If you're an EU/EEA student, check your coverage

Don't assume your European Health Insurance Card (EHIC) will suffice for the duration of your studies. An EHIC only provides limited, short-term coverage and often doesn't meet Dutch requirements.

Verify whether your current health insurance from home covers studying in the Netherlands. If it doesn't fully comply with Dutch norms, you should purchase additional student insurance or an add-on plan for coverage in the Netherlands.

3 If you're a non-EU student, use the Fontys-arranged student insurance

For students requiring a visa/residence permit, Fontys University typically arranges an international student health insurance as part of your immigration process. This is often provided by InsureToStudy (Master Plan+), which covers healthcare, pre-existing medical conditions, and extra benefits like liability and repatriation. After Fontys arranges it, you'll receive instructions to pay the insurance premium directly to the insurer.

4 Consider the recommended student insurance (InsureToStudy)

Fontys recommends InsureToStudy as a student-friendly insurer, offering comprehensive packages that include health care, liability, repatriation, accidents, legal aid, and even baggage coverage.

 **Tip:** Use the institution code "**FONTYSITS**" when signing up with your Fontys student email to get a student discount on the premium.

5 Know when you need Dutch basic health insurance (if you work)

If you take on a part-time job, paid internship, or otherwise start working alongside your studies, Dutch law requires you to enroll in a basic Dutch health insurance plan. You have a couple of options:

Option A: Combine student insurance with basic insurance

Keep your student insurance and add a Dutch basic insurance. InsureToStudy offers a combination package so that you're covered on days you work (by the Dutch insurance) and on days you don't (by the student insurance).

Option B: Switch entirely to Dutch basic insurance

Switch fully to a Dutch basic health insurance policy once you start working. Monthly premiums are roughly around €130 per month (varies by insurer). You may be eligible for a healthcare allowance (zorgtoeslag) from the Dutch government to offset the cost.

 **Warning:** Failing to take Dutch health insurance when you are obligated to have it can result in fines from the authorities.

6 Stay insured at all times

Once you have arranged the appropriate insurance, maintain it throughout your stay. If your situation changes (for example, you stop working or extend your studies), update your insurance accordingly. Fontys and the Dutch government cannot be held responsible for students who are uninsured – it's your duty to keep your insurance in order.

Registering with the Municipality and Getting Your BSN

Why is this important?

If you will live in the Netherlands for more than four months, you are required to register as a resident with the local municipality (gemeente). This is how you obtain your Burger Service Nummer (BSN), the Dutch citizen service number. Your BSN unlocks many other services: you need it to open a Dutch bank account, take out insurance, get paid from a job, and much more.

1 Schedule your city hall registration appointment early

You should register within the first five days of arriving in the Netherlands if you'll stay longer than 4 months. Check the website of the municipality where you'll live to make an appointment for a "first time registration" (in Dutch: inschrijven vanuit het buitenland).

In some student cities, the university and city hall organize special registration days on campus for international students – be sure to ask Fontys or check your introduction schedule to see if such an arrangement is available.

2 Prepare the required documents

When you go to your appointment, you must bring certain documents so the municipality can register you:

✓ Valid ID

A valid passport (for non-EU citizens) or national ID card (for EU/EEA citizens). A driver's license is not acceptable.

✓ Proof of address in the Netherlands

Typically a rental contract or housing agreement for your room/apartment. If staying with a relative or friend, you need a permission form signed by the main occupant plus a copy of their ID.

✓ Birth certificate

An original birth certificate (or certified true copy) issued within the last 6 months. If not in Dutch, English, French, or German, you must provide an official translation by a sworn translator.

The certificate may need an apostille or legalization from your home country to verify its authenticity for international use.

✓ Proof of civil status (if applicable)

If you are married, divorced, or widowed, bring marriage or divorce certificates.

✓ IND documents (for non-EU students)

If you come from outside the EU/EEA/Switzerland, bring any paperwork from the Immigration Office (IND) such as approval letters, passport stickers, or residence permit cards.

✓ Proof of enrollment (helpful)

A copy of your Fontys admission or enrollment letter. While not always strictly required, it can smooth out any questions during registration.

 **Tip:** Bring both originals and a few copies of these documents. Municipal officers will want to see originals, but having copies ready saves time.

3 Go to the appointment and register

On the day of your appointment, arrive a bit early at City Hall or the Expat Center with all your documents. When called, an officer will review your paperwork and enter your details into the Personal Records Database (BRP).

The appointment is usually straightforward and short – often about 10 minutes if everything is in order. Don't worry, you can speak English; Dutch municipalities deal with international students regularly and usually have English-speaking staff.

4 Receive your BSN (Burgerservicenummer)

Upon completing your registration, the municipality will issue your unique BSN number. In many cases, they will hand you a print-out of your registration details that includes your BSN on the spot. In other cases, the city might send your BSN by mail to your new address within a couple of weeks.

 **Important:** Keep your BSN safe and memorize it or store it securely. This number will be needed for virtually all official matters in the Netherlands, including opening a bank account, taking out insurance, and starting any job.

5 After registration – next steps

With your BSN in hand, you can proceed to handle other practical matters:

- Open a Dutch bank account (many banks require a BSN)
- Arrange Dutch basic health insurance if you started working
- Apply for a DigiD (digital identity login for government services)
- Keep your registration details updated if you move to a new address

6 Don't forget to deregister when leaving

If after your studies you leave the Netherlands for more than 8 months, you must deregister from the municipality (sign out of the BRP). This can usually be done by submitting a form or visiting city hall before you depart.

While you are studying and living here, do not stay unregistered. Failing to register, or living at an address different from what is on record, is against the law. As of 2025, municipalities can impose fines (around €325) if you don't register or if you neglect to update an address change in time.

Quick Reference Checklist

Health Insurance

- ☐ Arrange insurance before/upon arrival
- ☐ EU students: Check EHIC coverage
- ☐ Non-EU: Fontys arranges insurance
- ☐ Use code "FONTYSITS" for discount
- ☐ Working? Get Dutch basic insurance

Municipal Registration

- ☐ Schedule appointment within 5 days
- ☐ Bring passport/ID
- ☐ Bring rental contract
- ☐ Bring birth certificate + apostille
- ☐ Receive BSN number
- ☐ Apply for DigiD

Welcome to Fontys!

By following this guide on arranging your health insurance and municipality registration, you'll set yourself up for a smooth start in the Netherlands. With valid insurance coverage and a BSN number in your wallet, you can focus on settling into student life at Fontys knowing that the bureaucratic essentials are all taken care of.

Welcome to the Netherlands, and good luck with your studies!



Sources: The information in this guide is drawn from official student guides and Dutch government resources, including Fontys University's international student information on health insurance and municipal registration requirements, as well as the Dutch government's and Study in NL's guidelines on registering for a BSN.

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